

St. Thomas of Aquinas's Five Ways (plus a little context), from *Summa Theologiae* (Part 1, Question 2)

Question 2. The existence of God

1. Whether it is self-evident that God exists
2. Whether it is demonstrable
3. Whether God exists

Article 1. Whether it is self-evident [*per se notum*] that God exists

Objection 1. It seems that the existence of God is self-evident. Now those things are said to be self-evident to us the knowledge of which is naturally implanted in us, as we can see in regard to first principles. But as Damascene says (*De Fide Orth.* i, 1, 3), “the knowledge of God is naturally implanted in all.” Therefore the existence of God is self-evident.

Objection 2. Further, those things are said to be self-evident which are known as soon as the terms are known, which the Philosopher (*Post. Anal.* 1.3) says is true of the first principles of demonstration. Thus, when the nature of a whole and of a part is known, it is at once recognized that every whole is greater than its part. But as soon as the signification of the word *God* is understood, it is at once seen that God exists. For by this word is signified that thing than which nothing greater can be signified. But that which exists in reality and in the understanding is greater than that which exists only in the understanding. Therefore, since as soon as the word *God* is understood it exists in the understanding, it also follows that it exists in reality. Therefore, *God exists* is self-evident.

Objection 3. Further, the existence of truth is self-evident. For whoever denies the existence of truth grants that truth does not exist: and, if truth does not exist, then *Truth does not exist* is true: and if there is anything true, there must be truth. But God is truth itself: “I am the way, the truth, and the life” (John 14:6). Therefore *God exists* is self-evident.

On the contrary, No one can mentally admit the opposite of what is self-evident; as the Philosopher (*Metaph.* iv, lect. vi) states concerning the first principles of demonstration. But the opposite of *God is* can be thought, according to Psalms 52:1: “The fool said in his heart, There is no God”. Therefore, that God exists is not self-evident.

I answer that, A thing can be self-evident [*per se notum*] in either of two ways: on the one hand, self-evident in itself, though not to us; on the other, self-evident in itself, and to us. A proposition is self-evident because the predicate is included in the essence of the subject, as *Man is an animal*, for animal is contained in the essence of man. If, therefore the essence of the predicate and subject be known to all, the proposition will be self-evident to all; as is clear with regard to the first principles of demonstration, the terms of which are common things that no one is ignorant of, such as being and non-being, whole and part, and the like. If, however, there are some to whom the essence of the predicate and subject is unknown, the proposition will be self-evident in itself, but not to those who do not know the meaning of the predicate and subject of the proposition. Therefore, it happens, as Boethius says (*Hebdom.*, “Whether all that is, is good”), “that there are some mental concepts self-evident only to the learned, e.g. incorporeal substances are not in space.” I say, therefore, that this proposition *God exists* is self-evident in itself, for the predicate is the same as the subject, because God is his own existence [*esse*], as will be clear later [*ST* I. 3–4]. But because we do not know of God what he is, the proposition is not self-evident to us, but needs to be demonstrated by those [things] that are more known to us, though less known in their nature—viz., by effects.

Reply to Objection 1. To the first, therefore, it is to be said that to know that God exists [in a common thing under a certain confusion] is naturally implanted in us, viz. inasmuch as God is the beatitude of man. For

← Anselm’s ontological argument, stated

← relation between God’s essence and God’s existence

man naturally desires happiness, and what is naturally desired by man must be naturally known to him. This, however, is not to know absolutely that God exists; just as to know that someone is approaching is not the same as to know that Peter is approaching, even though it is Peter who is approaching; for many there are who imagine that man's perfect good which is happiness, consists in riches, and others in pleasures, and others in something else.

Reply to Objection 2. To the second it is to be said that perhaps he who hears this name *God* does not understand that *something than which nothing greater can be thought* is signified, since some have believed that God is a body. Yet, even if it is granted that anyone soever understands this name *God* to signify what has been said, viz. *that than which nothing greater can be thought*, nevertheless, it does not therefore follow that he understands what is signified by the name to be in reality [*in rerum natura*], but only in the apprehension of the intellect. Nor can it be argued that it is in reality [*in re*]*—unless it were granted that there is in reality something than which nothing greater can be thought, which is not granted by those positing that God does not exist.*

Reply to Objection 3. The existence of truth in general is self-evident but the existence of a primal truth is not self-evident to us.

**Article 2. Whether it can be
demonstrated that God exists?**

Objection 1. It seems that the existence of God cannot be demonstrated. For it is an article of faith that God exists. But what is of faith cannot be demonstrated, because a demonstration produces scientific knowledge; whereas faith is of the unseen (Hebrews 11:1). Therefore it cannot be demonstrated that God exists.

Objection 2. Further, the essence is the middle term of demonstration. But we cannot know in what God's essence consists, but solely in what it does not consist; as Damascene says (*De Fide Orth.* i, 4). Therefore we cannot demonstrate that God exists.

Objection 3. Further, if the existence of God were demonstrated, this could only be from His effects. But His effects are not proportionate to Him, since He is infinite and His effects are finite; and between the finite and infinite there is no proportion. Therefore, since a cause cannot be demonstrated by an effect not proportionate to it, it seems that the existence of God cannot be demonstrated.

On the contrary, The Apostle says: "The invisible things of Him are clearly seen, being understood by the things that are made" (Romans 1:20). But this would not be unless the existence of God could be demonstrated through the things that are made; for the first thing we must know of anything is whether it exists.

I answer that, Demonstration can be made in two ways: One is through the cause, and is called *propter quid* and this is to argue from what is prior absolutely. The other is through the effect, and is called a demonstration *quia*; this is to argue from what is prior only in relation to us. When an effect is better known to us than its cause, then from the effect we proceed to the knowledge of the cause. And from every effect the existence of its proper cause can be demonstrated (so long as its effects are better known to us), because since every effect depends upon its cause, if the effect exists, the cause must pre-exist. Hence the existence of God, in so far as it is not self-evident to us, can be demonstrated from those of His effects which are known to us.

Reply to Objection 1. The existence of God and other like truths about God, which can be known by natural reason, are not articles of faith, but are preambles to the articles; for faith presupposes natural knowledge, even as grace presupposes nature, and perfection supposes something that can be perfected. Nevertheless, there is nothing to prevent a man, who cannot grasp a proof, accepting, as a matter of faith, something which in itself is capable of being scientifically known and demonstrated.

Reply to Objection 2. When the existence of a cause is demonstrated from an effect, this effect takes the

← Anselm's ontological argument, reply

← general method for demonstrating God's existence

propter quid vs. *quia*

place of the definition of the cause in proof of the cause's existence. This is especially the case in regard to God, because, in order to prove the existence of anything, it is necessary to accept as a middle term the meaning of the word, and not its essence, for the question of its essence follows on the question of its existence. Now the names given to God are derived from His effects; consequently, in demonstrating the existence of God from His effects, we may take for the middle term the meaning of the word *God*.

Reply to Objection 3. From effects not proportionate to the cause no perfect knowledge of that cause can be obtained. Yet from every effect the existence of the cause can be clearly demonstrated, and so we can demonstrate the existence of God from His effects; though from them we cannot perfectly know God as He is in His essence.

Article 3. Whether God exists

Objection 1. It seems that God does not exist; because if one of two contraries be infinite, the other would be altogether destroyed. But the word "God" means that He is infinite goodness. If, therefore, God existed, there would be no evil discoverable; but there is evil in the world. Therefore God does not exist.

Objection 2. Further, it is unnecessary to suppose that what can be accounted for by a few principles has been produced by many. But it seems that everything we see in the world can be accounted for by other principles, supposing God did not exist. For all natural things can be reduced to one principle, viz. nature; and all voluntary things can be reduced to one principle, viz. human reason, or will. Therefore there is no need to posit God's existence.

On the contrary, It is said in the person of God: "I am Who am." (Exodus 3:14)

I answer that, The existence of God can be proved in five ways.

The first and more manifest way, however, is that taken from motion. For it is certain, and established by sense, that some [things] are moved in this world. But everything that is moved is moved by something else. For nothing is moved except inasmuch as it is in potency to that toward which it moves, whereas something moves inasmuch as it is in act. For to move is nothing else than to lead something out from potency into act, but something cannot be led back from potency into act except by some being [that is] in act, just as that which is hot in act, as [for example] fire, makes wood, which is hot in potency, to be actually hot, and thereby moves and alters it. But it is not possible that the same thing be simultaneously in act and in potency in the same respect, but only in different respects, for that which is hot in act cannot be simultaneously hot in potency, but is simultaneously cold in potency. It is therefore impossible that, in the same respect and in the same way, a thing be both moving and moved, or that it move itself. Therefore, everything that is moved must be moved by something else. If therefore that by which it is moved is itself moved, then this also must be moved by another, and that by yet another. But here there is no proceeding to infinity, because then there would be no prime mover, and, consequently, no other mover; because secondary movers do not move except inasmuch as they are moved by the prime mover, just as a walking staff does not move except inasmuch as it is moved by a hand. Therefore it is necessary to arrive at some prime mover, which is not moved by anything else; and this everyone understands to be God.

The second way is from the nature of the efficient cause. We find in sensible things that there is an order of efficient causes. But it is not found, nor is it possible, that anything is the efficient cause of itself, because thus it would be prior to itself, which is impossible. But in efficient causes it is not possible to proceed to infinity. For in all ordered efficient causes, the first is the cause of the intermediate [cause], and the intermediate is the cause of the ultimate [cause], whether there be many intermediate [causes], or only one. But with the cause removed, the effect is removed. Therefore, if there be no first cause among efficient causes, there will be neither an ultimate nor any intermediate. But if in efficient causes there is a proceeding to infinity, there is no first efficient cause, nor an ultimate effect, nor any intermediate efficient causes—which is patently false. Therefore it is necessary to posit a first efficient cause, to which everyone gives the name of God.

← problem of evil, stated

← explanatory parsimony

← First Way

This is a cosmological argument. It's sometimes called the *prime mover* or *unmoved mover* argument, or the *argument from motion* or *argument from change*.

Aquinas takes the argument from Aristotle (*Physics* 8), who speaks of κίνησις (*kinesis*) where Aquinas speaks of *motus*. This isn't quite *motion*: they don't just mean moving from one location to another (so-called *local motion*), but all (or nearly all) kinds of change.

When *a* is changing, it's being changed by some changing *b*, which is being changed by some changing *c*, ..., with the changes depending on the prior changes, as in the example of the stick and the hand. Thus, to avoid an infinite regress, there must be an original source of change that is *unchanging*.

← Second Way

This is also a cosmological argument, and a classic first cause argument, but it's usually called the *argument from efficient causes*.

Be careful with 'prior': when *x* comes prior to *y* in the order of efficient causes, that doesn't mean *x* is earlier in time than *y*.

The third way is taken from the possible and the necessary, which is as follows. Now, we find in reality some [things] that are possible to be and not to be, since some are found to be generated and corrupted, and consequently possible to be and not to be. But it is impossible for everything there is to be like this, because that which is possible not to be, at some time isn't. If therefore everything is possible not to be, then at some time there wasn't anything in reality. But if this is true, even now there wouldn't be anything, because what *isn't* does not start to be except through something that *is*; if therefore not anything was a being, it was impossible for something to start to be, and thus there wouldn't be anything now—which is patently false. Therefore not all beings are possible [i.e. possible to be and not to be], but it must be that something in reality is necessary. Now everything necessary either has or does not have a cause of its necessity from elsewhere. But it is not possible to proceed to infinity in necessities that have a cause of their necessity, no more than with efficient causes, as has been proved. Therefore it is necessary to posit something that is necessary through itself [*per se necessarium*], not having a cause of necessity from elsewhere, but that is the cause of necessity to others—which all call God.

The fourth way is taken from the gradation to be found in reality. Now, in reality there is found something more and less good, and true, and noble, and so on concerning others of this kind. But 'more' and 'less' are said of different things according as they approach in their different ways to something that maximally is, just as what more approaches to the maximally hot is more hot. There is therefore something that is truest, and best, and noblest, and consequently maximally being, for those that are maximally true are maximally beings, as it is written in *Metaph.* ii. But what is said to be maximally such in some genus is the cause of everything of that genus, just as fire, which is maximally hot, is the cause of everything hot, as is said in the same book. Therefore there is something that is to all beings the cause of being, and of goodness, and of any other perfection, and this we call God.

The fifth way is taken from the governance of things. Now, we see that some [things] which lack cognition, namely natural bodies, operate for the sake of an end, which appears from the fact that they operate always or more often in the same way, so that they attain what is best; from which it is clear that it is not by chance, but by intention, that they arrive at their end. But those that do not have cognition do not tend toward an end unless directed by something cognizing and understanding [*intelligente*], just like an arrow by an archer. Therefore there is something intelligent, by which all natural things are ordered to an end, and this we call God.

Reply to Objection 1. To the first, therefore, it is to be said that, just as Augustine says in the *Enchiridion* [ch. 11], God, *since he is supremely good, would by no means permit anything of evil to be in his works, if he were not so very almighty and good that even from evil would he achieve good.* This, therefore, pertains to the infinite goodness of God: that he permits evils to exist, and draws goods out of them.

Reply to Objection 2. To the second it is to be said that, since nature operates for a determined end by the direction of some higher agent, it is necessary that those [things] that come about by nature also be traced back to God, as to a first cause. Likewise, those [things] that come about by deliberate purpose must be traced back to some higher cause—which is not of the kind to be human reason and will, for these are changeable and defectible; but everything movable and capable of defection must be traced back to some first principle that is immovable and necessary through itself, as has been shown.

← Third Way

This is also a cosmological argument, a version of the *argument from contingency*.

First, Aquinas argues that there must be a necessary being, in addition to the contingent beings.

Second, Aquinas argues that there must be a being that's necessary *per se*, in addition to the other necessary beings.

← Fourth Way

This argument doesn't belong to a well-known category of argument. It's called the *argument from degree* or *argument from gradation*.

← Fifth Way

This is a teleological argument, or design argument.

Aquinas has a traditional conception of nature with bodies operating for good ends (e.g. trees), not the modern conception of nature as a machine operating by uniform mechanical laws (e.g. clocks).

← problem of evil, reply

← explanatory parsimony, reply